Live and in Color

By Danitra Vance

INTRODUCTION

Danitra Vance was an American comedienne and actress best known as a cast member on the NBC sketch show Saturday Night Live. Diagnosed with breast cancer in 1990, Vance underwent a single mastectomy. The cancer recurred in 1993 and she died of the disease the following year. In Live and in Color we get to experience her unique form of humor as she address some very serious topics: PMS and it's impact on women, AIDS and the very cancer that ultimately killed this very talented performer. Live and in Color by Danitra Vance.

Sometimes I wake up screaming.

Sometimes I believe I'm clinically depressed.

Maybe my show is on. *(She turns on the TV using the remote control)* Naaaa. *(She turns off the TV with the remote. She picks up the Singleton Maxwell notebook and reads)*

Singleton Maxwell M.D./Midol Junkie

This message is for women only because men really don't have a clue, do they. Adam was not a rough draft, Adam was a doodle. Ladies, I am Singleton Maxwell M.D., the woman gynecologist that designed the O.B. Method. I am currently on a lecture tour, with a presentation entitled WARNING: THE DANGER OF BEING A WOMAN. I have spoken before many prestigious groups including most recently a joint meeting of the League of Women Intellectuals and the Sluts Against Smut. I became a gynecologist because of my gynecological mysteries.

Our combined gynecological mysteries prompted me to write a pamphlet *(Shows cover)* Between Your Legs and You. You can pick it up almost anywhere. In the book, I postulate: "Is there a Capitalist plot against women?" I mean to say ... Why is it

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that whenever I have monthly pain the first thing I think of is, Give me strength, give me antiprostaglandins, give me antispasmodics, give me drugs.

(She puts on her sunglasses. Traditional blues music underscores the following monologue. She sings:)

In the kitchen barefoot expecting my eighth child I must take my Midol, so I don't go wild

I'm a Midol junkie and I don't know why

Keeps me feeling funky so I take it all the time

It helps before, during and after

Gives me laughter through my tears

I've been on it for years

It helps my lower back pain

Takes away the strain of being a Woman Woman Woman WOMAN, WO-O-O-M-A-A-A-N

Yes I'm a Woman W-O ... W-O *(Forgets lyrics)* Yes I'm a Woman W-O *(Still can't remember)*

(Spoken) Baby, you don't know me. I killed my first husband. It wasn't really my fault, though. It all happened the night before my *monthly* was supposed to start and I am sure it was the hormonal imbalance that led me to commit murder. "Did I have to kill him?" "Did I have to kill him?" "Did I have to kill him?" Yes, I had to kill him. He hit me, and I always told myself I would never stay with anybody who hit me. While I packed, the scenario unfolded. I leave him, he finds me, he looks pitiful and boyish, I forgive him, we spend six blissful months together. He hits me again, harder, then he says, "I'm sorry, Baby, I love you more than life itself, doesn't six

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months of bliss mean anything to you?" He cries, I cry, a year of happiness until he loses his job, bam bam bam, he buys me a puppy, a cute little black springer spaniel, he kicks the dog ... I'm living the life of the battered wife. I watch Oprah and Phil and Sally and Shirley and Jane and Wilma and Betty and Veronica ... I started to wonder who would play me in the made-for-TV version of my life. My lawyer said for me to plead insanity, and I said I thought that was just for men. I went to prison.

(Singing:)

W-O ... W-O ... Oh you know,

Oh you know, o. u. know, all of you know. I may not be able to spell my name

but Midol keeps me tame

when I'm feeling evil.

(Spoken) Take only as directed.

TRANSITION

Today there is more feeling than ever that television is cheapening the news and that the audience is allowing this to happen and even encouraging it by giving high ratings to so-called trash television--tabloid news programs and sensationalistic talk programs. We interrupt this life to take you "LIVE AND IN COLOR" -- the very type of reality television show – The American Talk show – that dominates the lives a millions of stay-at-home mothers throughout the nation.

Television Talk Show

WOMAN GUEST: When I got to LAX, there was no one there to meet me, so I took the shuttle. By the time I got off at Phil and Chris's, a guy there told me

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Chris had to go to the emergency room and when they came home, Chris went to bed. Phil told me that Chris had AIDS and that he, Phil, was HIV positive.
I thought to myself, it's a good thing I am who I am or this could be ... not too cute. I didn't know a lot about AIDS. I shook hands with a person with AIDS before 1 knew what it was. What I'm saying is I never lived with someone with AIDS. I never lived with someone HIV positive and I was afraid. I was afraid I'd turn stupid. Part of me thought I might throw up my hands and run screaming from the house. I mean part of me wanted to want to do that. That was a few years ago and AIDS was in the paper and on the news every day and everyone seemed to be a little hysterical. I guess I'm not a hysterical person.

HOST: You say you're not a hysterical person. If there was a time for hysteria, it would have been then. Had you seen something or read something that-

WOMAN GUEST: I had seen you on your talk show.

HOST: You know, I always like to think this show performs a public service, that it enlightens and educates-

WOMAN GUEST: No. You had a PWA on your show and the entire audience hated him. And you never touched him. You didn't shake his hand. You even sat in a chair or two away from him and stretched your microphone over to him. You could have taught this country to be humane but you seemed to side with ignorance. Even your expert doctor said he couldn't guarantee these were the only ways to get the

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virus. I knew I didn't want to be like you.

HOST: You seem to ... You've given us so much ... Let's go to a commercial right now. *(Camera is turned off.)* I don't know who you think you are, but this is my show. How dare you get up on national television and humiliate *me!*

WOMAN GUEST: How dare you get up on national television and dehumanize every person with AIDS. Where was all that compassion and intelligence you talk-show hosts are supposed to have?

HOST: Let me tell you something, Miss Holier Than Me, I am famous for my compassion, my sympathy, my empathy, my Ph.D. *People* magazine named me one of this year's "Most Fabulous People" because of my warmth and compassion.

WOMAN GUEST: I used to feel the same way until I saw that show.

HOST: We're coming back from commercial in about one minute and I want you to tell the viewing audience you saw that on someone else's show. Tell them I didn't do that.

WOMAN GUEST: Honey, when you come back from commercial, you won't have a guest to talk to. I didn't come here for this.

HOST: Oh! Believe me, I can run this show without you or any other guest. But let's see how you run the show without me. *(Walks off the set)*

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WOMAN GUEST *(To audience):* How many of you saw that show? It was a few years ago. *(No response)* If the host doesn't come back, will some of you go to the microphones and ask me questions about living with someone who has AIDS or-

VOICE OF THE DIRECTOR: We're back!

(Woman Guest looks blank, clueless, lonely. She looks toward the wings for the Host. She looks toward the audience. "Help" is written in her eyes. If an audience member gets up, we'll take the question. If not .. .)

You're turning stupid

WOMAN GUEST: I didn't want to turn stupid. I gave Phil a big real hug.

Not a cheek-to-cheek, hand-on-the-shoulders hug, a *real* hug. And I hugged Chris the same way. But stupidity always lurked somewhere. *(Screams)* The toilet seat! I always put tissue on the seat. That's how my grandmother raised me. Maybe I should sit on the bare seat to prove I wasn't afraid of AIDS. Prove to who? *(Screams)* The shower! I can't get it from taking a shower. EEK! The razors! I don't use other people's razors anyway. Dishes! Couldn't I be the first, the very first person to contract AIDS in some odd, unusual way? I mean, doctors and nurses in hospitals wear gloves and masks and stuff. Yes! No! Maybe. Yes! No! Stop it!

I wasn't having sex with them. I had never had a blood transfusion. I was not an IV drug user. If there was some other way for me to get AIDS, some other way no one knew about, then okay. I would be an innocent victim just like Phil and Chris and everyone fighting this syndrome or that disease or any other malady.

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Not long after that, I found this lump in my breast. I had a mastectomy. Then I started this book. All proceeds go to the National Fund for Sick People. *Funny Things People Say to People That Are Sick:*

"I thought you were dead."
"Why don't you have the other one removed?" "How are you?"
You can ask me questions now. *(Questions from audience. Pause.)*

Oh, okay, nobody wants to talk to me. I can see some of you are wearing red ribbons. Big deal. What difference does that make? Go hold a crack baby. Go hold an AIDS baby. You want a medal for that? If that ribbon was made out of ten pounds of steel that you had to sling over your shoulder, that might say something. "Count me, too. I'm struggling, too." Fifty thousand women die every year of breast cancer. Wear a ten-pound ribbon for them and one for lupus and one for diabetes and every other life-threatening, life-altering- Since this is a talk show, and since this is *my* talk show. That's all I have to say.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Danitra Vance
Book: Moon Marked and Touched by Sun (ed Sydne Mahone)
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011National Qualifier
IL State Finalist

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